The key protagonists and their roles, the almost daily twists and turns in policy, the nationwide distress and inconvenience, the sting operations and raids on hoarders of black money and corrupt bankers – all made for fascinating copy and viewing, except for those whose livelihood it wiped out.

It was a bleak and overcast day in Delhi. We had arrived in the city from Mumbai by the Rajdhani Express on the morning of 8 November 2016. We were on a pilgrimage of sorts. My mother wished to visit the holy shrines of Salim Chishti in Ajmer, the Brahma temple in Pushkar, and the Gurdwara of Guru Gobind Singh in Gurdaspur. Delhi was to be our base. The smog and pollution that greeted us on our arrival, making breathing difficult, were, perhaps, a dire precursor of the events that were about to unfold.

My attention, like that of millions across the world, was focussed on the Clinton vs. Trump US presidential election, the result of which was to be announced that night. Through my interactions with her, I had grown to respect and admire Hillary Clinton greatly. Sitting glued to the television, I was hoping she would breach the glass ceiling and enter the White House.

As early reports of the US elections started coming in, there was a newsflash, signalling an important announcement by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, at 8 p.m. As his broadcast began, all thoughts of the momentous US elections were pushed to the background. We were stunned to hear Prime Minister Modi announce, first in Hindi and then in English, that from the midnight on 8 November 2016, India's ₹1,000 and 500 notes would be no longer legal tender and would become worthless pieces of paper.

Many swiftly dubbed the move as a 'surgical strike', in apparent reference to the attack conducted by the Indian Army a few weeks earlier against terrorist bases in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.[1]

It was a dramatic announcement, salient excerpts of which are below (see full text of the Prime Minister's speech in Appendix 1):